From the outset, Operation Anadyr was conducted in strictest secrecy. Anadyr was the name of a Siberian River, one of many ruses to disguise the destination of the ships as they embarked on voyages of up to 7,000-miles. The aim was to complete the deployment in November. Khrushchev did not want his action to become known before the US mid-term Congressional elections (on 6 November); and he intended to visit Cuba in late November en route to the United Nations in December. He would have the opportunity to announce that Soviet nuclear missiles now protected Cuba.

The Presidium unanimously endorsed the General Staff plan on 24 May. From the limited records available, it is not known what was said at the meeting, though seven members spoke in support (including Anastas Mikoyan).[63] Operation Anadyr depended, of course, on Cuban acceptance of Soviet nuclear weapons. Alekseev had told Khrushchev and his colleagues that Castro would not want to undermine his efforts to foment revolution in Central and South America, nor his recent demand that all foreign bases be removed from Cuba (to get rid of the US from Guantánamo). Despite reservations, however, Castro and his colleagues accepted the proposal. Raul Castro was particularly enthusiastic. When Havana's agreement was reported to the Presidium on 10 June there was complete support for Khrushchev's strategy.

Fidel Castro nevertheless emphasised that in accepting the missiles for the defence of Cuba, Havana was also contributing to the international struggle against imperialism. He believed that, as a sovereign nation, Cuba had the right to accept whatever it chose on its own territory. Any agreement should therefore be made public. Secrecy added weight to the accusation that Cuba was being treated as a satellite rather than behaving as an ally. In 1992 Castro described this aspect of Khrushchev's strategy as, 'a big mistake, a very big mistake'. He believed secrecy and deception were each 'very damaging'.[64]

Khrushchev was unmoved by Castro's concerns (and the agreement was never formally signed or published). Keeping the missiles hidden until they were operational was central to a political strategy that involved presenting Washington with a *fait accompli*, while not creating undue domestic problems for Kennedy ahead of the mid-term elections (so Khrushchev